



Mavilo Pet Co.

HAPPY PETS, PRACTICAL CARE

PRINTABLE GUIDE



SALON-FRESH RESULTS AT HOME

At-Home Dog Grooming Guide

Brushing, bathing, nails, ears, teeth and paws — step-by-step techniques, the right tools for every coat, and tips to keep grooming calm and stress-free.



WHAT'S INSIDE

- Coat types & the right tools
- Brushing & bathing step by step
- Nail trimming without fear
- Ear cleaning & tooth brushing
- Paw care & seasonal tips
- Stress-free grooming methods
- Schedule by coat type
- Printable monthly checklist

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Coat types covered

Step-by-step

Techniques for every task

Monthly

Printable grooming checklist



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HOW TO USE THIS PDF

Read it on screen or print the whole thing. Worksheet pages are designed to be printed again and again, so feel free to print extra copies of any tracker you use often. Tip: print at "Actual size" on US Letter paper.

Welcome to At-Home Grooming

Grooming isn't just about looking good — it's one of the best ways to keep your dog healthy and comfortable.

Regular grooming removes loose hair and dirt, prevents painful mats, keeps nails at a healthy length and gives you a chance to spot problems early: lumps, ticks, skin irritation, ear infections or sore paws. It's also wonderful bonding time. With the right tools and a patient approach, most grooming can be done at home in a few minutes a week.

The at-home grooming starter kit

- ☐ Brush(es) matched to your dog's coat (see next section)
- ☐ Stainless-steel comb with wide and fine teeth
- ☐ Dog shampoo (and conditioner for long coats)
- ☐ Absorbent towels + non-slip bath mat
- ☐ Handheld sprayer or large cup for rinsing
- ☐ Nail clippers (scissor or guillotine style) or a nail grinder
- ☐ Styptic powder (or cornstarch) for nail nicks
- ☐ Vet-recommended dog ear cleaner + cotton balls or gauze
- ☐ Dog toothbrush or finger brush + dog toothpaste
- ☐ High-value treats, lick mat, and plenty of patience

Golden rules

Short & sweet

Several 5-minute sessions beat one long wrestling match. Stop before your dog gets fidgety.

Treats for everything

Pair every touch, tool and sound with something your dog loves. It builds positive associations.

Safety first

Use non-slip surfaces, never leave a dog on a table unattended, and keep sharp tools pointed away from skin.

YOUR WEEKLY HEALTH CHECK

While grooming, gently run your hands over your whole dog. Look for lumps, bumps, cuts, hot spots, fleas, flea dirt (black specks that turn red on a damp paper towel), ticks, redness, odor, or anything that's new. Note changes and share them with your vet.

Important: This guide is general education, not veterinary advice; consult your veterinarian about your own pet's health, diet, medications, and any symptoms that concern you. If your dog has a skin condition, ear infection, injury, or pain, have them seen by your veterinarian before grooming the area.

Coat Types & Brushing Tools

Every coat has different needs. Find your dog's type below, then choose tools to match.

Coat type	Example breeds	What it needs	Best tools
Smooth / short	Boxer, Beagle, Dachshund (smooth), Doberman, Pit Bull types	Weekly brushing to remove loose hair and distribute skin oils	Rubber curry brush, bristle brush, grooming mitt
Double coat	Labrador, Golden Retriever, German Shepherd, Husky, Corgi	Frequent brushing, especially during seasonal shedding ("coat blow")	Slicker brush, undercoat rake, wide-tooth comb, de-shedding tool (use gently)
Long / silky	Yorkshire Terrier, Shih Tzu, Maltese, Afghan Hound	Daily or every-other-day brushing to prevent tangles and mats	Pin brush, slicker brush, fine and wide-tooth comb, detangling spray
Curly / low-shedding	Poodle, Bichon Frisé, Portuguese Water Dog, doodles	Brushing several times a week to the skin; professional haircuts every 4–8 weeks	Slicker brush, long-tooth comb, mat splitter (with care)
Wire	Schnauzer, Wire Fox Terrier, West Highland Terrier, Airedale	Weekly brushing; hand-stripping or clipping a few times a year	Slicker brush, comb, stripping knife (or professional stripping)
Hairless / very fine	Chinese Crested, American Hairless Terrier, Xoloitzcuintli	Skin care: gentle baths, moisturizing, sun protection as advised by your vet	Soft cloth, gentle shampoo, dog-safe moisturizer

Meet the tools

Slicker brush

Fine wire bristles for removing tangles and loose undercoat. Use a light touch — pressing hard can cause "brush burn."

Pin brush

Rounded pins glide through long coats and finish the look. Great for silky coats.

Bristle brush

Soft bristles smooth short coats and add shine by spreading natural oils.

Rubber curry

Loosens dead hair and massages the skin. Perfect for short coats and during baths.

Undercoat rake

Long teeth reach through the topcoat to lift shedding undercoat on double-coated dogs.

Steel comb

The "truth-teller": if the comb glides from skin to tip, you've brushed thoroughly.

SHOULD I SHAVE MY DOUBLE-COATED DOG?

Generally, no. A double coat helps insulate your dog from both heat and cold and protects the skin from sunburn. Shaving can also change how the coat grows back. Regular brushing to remove loose undercoat is the better way to keep them comfortable. Ask your vet or groomer if there's a medical reason to clip.

Brushing Technique

Brushing the right way prevents mats, reduces shedding and keeps skin healthy.

Step by step

- 1 **Set up:** Choose a calm time (after a walk works well). Have treats ready and your dog on a non-slip mat.
- 2 **Start easy:** Begin with areas your dog enjoys, like the back and shoulders. Brush in the direction the hair grows.
- 3 **Line brush longer coats:** Lift a section of hair with one hand and brush the hair below it down, working from the skin outward in small rows. This reaches the skin instead of just skimming the top.
- 4 **Work the friction zones:** Mats form fastest behind the ears, in the armpits, on the chest, where the collar or harness sits, on the belly, and on the back of the legs ("britches").
- 5 **Comb to check:** Run a steel comb through each area from skin to tip. If it catches, go back with the brush.
- 6 **Finish and reward:** End with a few long strokes, a treat and praise.

Dealing with tangles and mats

Small tangles

Hold the hair at the base (between the mat and the skin) so you don't pull on the skin. Tease the tangle apart with your fingers or the end tooth of a comb, working from the outside edge inward. A little detangling spray or cornstarch can help.

Tight or large mats

Don't force them out, and **don't cut mats with scissors** — it's very easy to cut skin that's pulled up into the mat. Tight mats close to the skin are best shaved out by a professional groomer using clippers.

Shedding season survival

- Double-coated dogs often "blow" their undercoat in spring and fall. Brush daily for a few weeks during a heavy shed.
- Brushing outside or on an old sheet keeps the fluff contained.
- A warm bath followed by a thorough dry and brush-out helps release loose undercoat.
- Go gently with de-shedding tools that have a blade edge: a few light strokes per area, and avoid thin-skinned spots.

PRO TIP

Brush *before* every bath. Water tightens mats and tangles, making them much harder to remove afterward.

Bathing Step by Step

Most dogs need a bath every 4–8 weeks, or when they're dirty or smelly. Your vet may recommend a different routine for skin conditions.

- 1 **Gather everything first:** dog shampoo, towels, cup or sprayer, non-slip mat, treats, and a lick mat smeared with a dog-safe spread to stick to the tub wall. Never leave your dog alone in the tub.
- 2 **Brush thoroughly** to remove loose hair and tangles.
- 3 **Check the water:** lukewarm, like a baby's bath. Test it on your inner wrist.
- 4 **Wet from the neck back:** Soak the coat all the way to the skin, starting at the neck and working back and down. Keep water out of the eyes, ears and nose; some owners place a cotton ball gently in the outer ear (remember to remove it).
- 5 **Lather:** Use a dog shampoo — human shampoo has a different pH and can irritate a dog's skin. Dilute it in a cup of water for easier spreading. Massage in, including legs, feet, belly and tail.
- 6 **Wash the face last** with a damp washcloth, avoiding the eyes.
- 7 **Rinse, rinse, rinse:** Leftover shampoo can cause itching and flaking. Rinse until the water runs clear and the coat feels squeaky clean, then rinse once more.
- 8 **Condition (optional):** For long or curly coats, apply dog conditioner, leave on as directed, and rinse well.
- 9 **Towel dry:** Squeeze (don't rub vigorously, which tangles long coats). Let your dog shake — hold up a towel as a shield!
- 10 **Finish drying:** Use a pet dryer or a human hair dryer on the *cool* or *low-heat* setting, kept moving and several inches from the skin. Brush as you dry for a fluffy finish. Thick coats must be dried to the skin to prevent hot spots.

CHOOSING A SHAMPOO

- **Everyday:** gentle, fragrance-light formula
- **Puppies:** mild puppy shampoo
- **Itchy or flaky skin:** ask your vet — medicated shampoos are best used under veterinary guidance
- **Avoid:** human shampoos, dish soap, and strong essential oils

BETWEEN BATHS

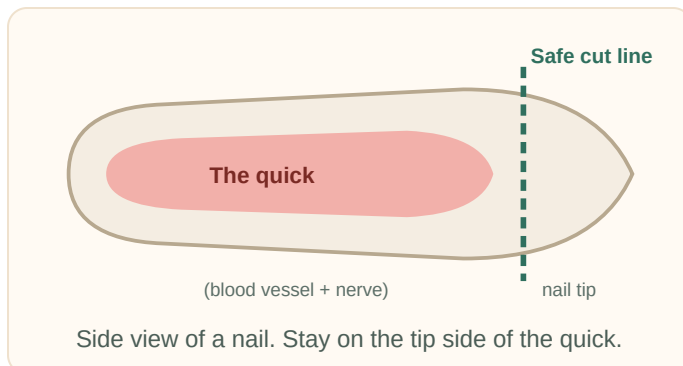
- Wipe paws and belly with a damp cloth after muddy walks
- Spot-clean with a dog-safe waterless shampoo
- Brush regularly — it keeps coats cleaner for longer
- Wash your dog's bedding weekly

Nail Trimming

Overgrown nails can change how your dog stands and walks. If you hear clicking on hard floors, it's time for a trim.

Understanding the quick

Inside each nail is the **quick**: a blood vessel and nerve. Cutting it hurts and bleeds. In **light-colored nails** the quick looks pink through the nail. In **dark nails** you can't see it, so trim tiny slivers and look at the cut surface: when you see a chalky white or gray ring with a **dark, moist-looking dot** appearing in the center, stop — you're close.



Step by step

- 1 Sit with your dog in good light. Hold a paw gently but securely, pressing lightly on the pad to extend the nail.
- 2 Trim a small piece at a slight angle, following the natural curve. With a grinder, touch the nail for 1–2 seconds at a time and keep it moving to avoid heat.
- 3 Don't forget the **dewclaws** on the inside of the legs — they don't touch the ground and can curl into the pad if neglected.
- 4 Treat after every nail (or every paw) at first. It's fine to do one paw a day.
- 5 Most dogs need a trim every 2–4 weeks. Frequent small trims encourage the quick to recede over time.

IF YOU CUT THE QUICK

Stay calm. Press styptic powder (or cornstarch/flour) onto the nail tip with gentle pressure for a minute or two until bleeding stops. Give a treat and end on an easy note. Call your vet if bleeding doesn't stop after several minutes of pressure.

CALM-HANDLING TIPS

- Practice touching paws daily, without clippers, for treats
- Let your dog sniff the clippers; click them near a treat
- Use a lick mat or have a helper feed treats slowly
- Work in a sit or lying down, whichever your dog prefers
- Stop at the first sign of stress and try again later

If your dog is very fearful or has thick, overgrown nails, ask your vet or groomer for help — they can trim safely and show you technique.

Ear Cleaning & Teeth Brushing

Two small habits that can prevent big (and expensive) problems.

Ear care

Check ears weekly. Healthy ears are pale pink with little or no wax and no strong smell. Dogs with floppy ears, hairy ear canals, or who swim often may need cleaning more often — ask your vet what's right for your dog.

- 1 Use an ear cleaner made for dogs and recommended by your vet.
- 2 Lift the ear flap and fill the canal with cleaner as directed on the label.
- 3 Gently massage the base of the ear for about 20–30 seconds (you'll hear a squishing sound).
- 4 Step back and let your dog shake.
- 5 Wipe the visible part of the ear with a cotton ball or gauze. Reward!

NEVER

- Push cotton swabs into the ear canal — they can pack debris deeper or injure the eardrum
- Use alcohol, hydrogen peroxide or vinegar unless your vet advises it
- Clean an ear that looks red, swollen or painful — see your vet first

See your vet if you notice: head shaking, scratching at ears, bad odor, dark or yellow discharge, redness, swelling, head tilt, or pain when the ear is touched.

Teeth brushing

Dental disease is one of the most common health problems in dogs, and most dogs show some signs of it by age three. Daily brushing is the gold standard; even a few times a week helps.

- 1 **Days 1–3:** Let your dog lick dog toothpaste from your finger.
- 2 **Days 4–6:** Lift the lip and rub a finger along the outer surfaces of the teeth.
- 3 **Days 7–10:** Introduce a finger brush or soft dog toothbrush with paste.
- 4 **Brushing:** Angle bristles about 45° toward the gumline and use small circles on the outer surfaces, especially the back teeth. 30 seconds per side is a great goal.

TOOTHPASTE MATTERS

Use **only dog toothpaste**. Human toothpaste isn't meant to be swallowed, and some contain **xylitol**, which is toxic to dogs. Look for dental products with the **VOHC** (Veterinary Oral Health Council) seal.

SIGNS TO WATCH

Bad breath, red or bleeding gums, brown tartar, loose or broken teeth, drooling, or chewing on one side. Your vet may recommend a professional dental cleaning.

Paw Care & Seasonal Tips

Paws carry your dog everywhere. A quick weekly check keeps them comfortable year-round.

Weekly paw check

- | | |
|--|---|
| ☐ Spread the toes and look for burrs, grass awns (foxtails), pebbles or splinters | ☐ Check nail length and dewclaws |
| ☐ Check pads for cracks, cuts, blisters or burns | ☐ Wipe paws after walks to remove dirt, salt and chemicals |
| ☐ Look for redness, swelling or licking between toes | ☐ Apply a dog-safe paw balm to dry pads if needed |
| ☐ Trim hair between pads so it's level with the pads (helps traction) | ☐ Watch for limping or excessive licking — call your vet |

PAVEMENT TEST

On warm days, press the back of your hand to the pavement for 7 seconds. If it's too hot for you, it's too hot for paws. Walk early or late, stick to grass and shade, and consider booties.

Seasonal grooming guide

Spring

- Heavy shedding for double coats — brush daily during the “blow”
- Ask your vet about flea, tick and heartworm prevention
- Muddy paws: keep a towel and water bowl by the door
- Check for ticks after every outdoor adventure

Summer

- Brush out undercoat to improve airflow (don't shave double coats)
- Rinse off chlorine or salt water after swimming, and dry ears well
- Check for foxtails in ears, nose, eyes and toes
- Ask your vet about pet-safe sunscreen for pink skin and thin coats

Autumn

- Second shedding season as the winter coat comes in
- Watch for burrs and seeds in feathered legs and tails
- Keep up with tick checks — ticks can stay active in cool weather
- Schedule a trim before the holidays

Winter

- Wipe paws after walks to remove ice-melt salt and chemicals
- Keep paw hair trimmed to prevent ice balls between toes
- Bathe less often if skin gets dry; always dry completely before going out
- Consider booties and a coat for small or short-coated dogs

ANTIFREEZE WARNING

Antifreeze (ethylene glycol) tastes sweet and is extremely toxic. Wipe up spills immediately, and call your vet or an animal poison control center right away if you suspect your dog licked any.

Making Grooming Stress-Free

The goal isn't just a clean dog — it's a dog who feels safe during care.

Many dogs find grooming uncomfortable because they're being restrained, handled in sensitive spots, or exposed to strange sounds. The good news: with patient, positive training, most dogs can learn to relax — or even enjoy it.

The step-by-step desensitization method

- 1 **Find the starting point:** What's the smallest version your dog is comfortable with? (Maybe just seeing the clippers from across the room.)
- 2 **Pair it with treats:** Tool appears → treat. Tool disappears → treats stop. Repeat until your dog looks happy when the tool appears.
- 3 **Take tiny steps:** Tool closer → tool touches paw → clipper sound near paw → one nail. Only move forward when your dog is relaxed at the current step.
- 4 **Keep sessions short:** 1–3 minutes, ending on success.

Cooperative care: the “chin rest”

Teach your dog to rest their chin on your hand, a towel or a cushion. While their chin stays down, you groom; if they lift their chin, you pause. This gives your dog a way to say “I need a break,” which often builds trust and tolerance quickly.

Helpful tools

- Lick mat with a dog-safe spread
- Non-slip mat or yoga mat for secure footing
- Towel wrap for small dogs (gentle, not tight)
- A helper to feed treats

Know the signs of stress

Mild stress — slow down	Moderate stress — pause and make it easier	High stress — stop
Lip licking, yawning, turning head away, whale eye (whites of eyes showing)	Panting when not hot, trembling, pulling paw away, refusing treats	Freezing, growling, snapping, struggling hard, trying to escape

WHEN TO GET HELP

If your dog growls, snaps or panics during grooming, stop and talk to your veterinarian. Pain (arthritis, ear infections, sore skin) is a common hidden cause. Your vet may suggest a professional groomer experienced with fearful dogs, a certified behavior professional, or discuss options to reduce anxiety for necessary care. Never punish growling — it's an important warning.

My dog's grooming notes

Favorite grooming treat _____ Best time of day _____

Most sensitive area _____ Progress goal _____

Grooming Schedule by Coat Type

Use this as a starting point, then adjust for your dog's lifestyle, skin, age and your vet's advice.

Coat type	Brushing	Bathing	Professional grooming	Nails	Ears	Teeth
Smooth / short	Weekly	Every 6–8 weeks or as needed	Rarely needed	Every 2–4 weeks	Check weekly	Daily if possible
Double coat	2–3× weekly; daily when shedding	Every 6–8 weeks	Optional de-shed every 2–3 months	Every 2–4 weeks	Check weekly	Daily if possible
Long / silky	Daily to every other day	Every 3–6 weeks	Trim every 4–8 weeks	Every 2–4 weeks	Check weekly; trim hair around ears	Daily if possible
Curly / low-shedding	3–4× weekly, to the skin	Every 3–6 weeks	Haircut every 4–8 weeks	Every 2–4 weeks	Check weekly (hair can trap moisture)	Daily if possible
Wire	Weekly	Every 6–8 weeks	Hand-strip or clip 2–4× a year	Every 2–4 weeks	Check weekly	Daily if possible
Hairless	Soft wipe-down as needed	Every 1–2 weeks (gentle)	Rarely needed	Every 2–4 weeks	Check weekly	Daily if possible

Everyday extras for every dog

Daily

- Teeth brushing
- Quick wipe of eye area if needed
- Paw wipe after walks

Weekly

- Full-body health check
- Ear check
- Paw & pad check
- Wash bedding

Monthly

- Weigh your dog
- Clean brushes and combs
- Replace worn toothbrush as needed
- Parasite prevention as prescribed

My dog's custom schedule

Task	How often	Day / time	Who does it	Notes
Brushing				
Bathing				
Nail trim				
Ear check / clean				
Teeth				
Paw check				
Groomer visit				

Printable Monthly Grooming Checklist

Print one per month. Check off each task when done and jot notes for your vet.

Dog's name _____

Month / year _____

Task	Week 1	Week 2	Week 3	Week 4	Notes
Brushing	☐	☐	☐	☐	
Comb-through / mat check	☐	☐	☐	☐	
Bath	☐	☐	☐	☐	
Nail trim	☐	☐	☐	☐	
Dewclaws	☐	☐	☐	☐	
Ear check	☐	☐	☐	☐	
Ear clean (if needed)	☐	☐	☐	☐	
Paw & pad check	☐	☐	☐	☐	
Trim paw hair	☐	☐	☐	☐	
Full-body lump & tick check	☐	☐	☐	☐	
Eye area wipe	☐	☐	☐	☐	
Wash bedding	☐	☐	☐	☐	
Clean tools	☐	☐	☐	☐	

Daily teeth brushing tracker

Check or color each day you brush.

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Anything to show the vet?

Wins this month



Happy grooming!

Thank you for choosing Mavilo Pet Co. Every brush stroke, nail trim and tooth brushing is an act of care — and with patience, a chance for your dog to learn that being handled is safe and rewarding. Start small, celebrate progress, and enjoy the extra cuddles with your fresh, fluffy friend.

Go slow

Short sessions and lots of treats build lasting trust.

Stay consistent

Little and often beats long, stressful sessions.

Ask for help

Your vet and groomer are great partners.

Mavilo Pet Co. · Happy pets, practical care

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